

ERLY Scholarship Essay

Ali Bel Haj Letaif

There was a moment in my academic journey when I had to make a decision that fundamentally shaped how I approach challenges today: either wait for perfect conditions or bet on myself despite uncertainty. I chose to bet on myself.

I am currently a graduate student in Software Engineering at Grand Valley State University, specializing in cloud computing, DevOps, and scalable system design. My academic journey as an international student has required continuous adaptation, resilience, and self-driven learning. Moving across different academic environments while pursuing advanced technical goals has taught me that success is not only about resources, but about mindset and persistence.

One of the most defining moments of “betting on myself” came when I decided to pursue advanced topics in cloud computing and DevOps, even though these areas were not fully covered in my earlier academic environment. At that time, I did not have structured mentorship or guaranteed academic support in these fields. Instead of seeing this as a limitation, I saw it as an opportunity to take ownership of my learning.

I began teaching myself technologies such as Docker, Kubernetes, CI/CD pipelines, and cloud platforms including AWS and Azure. This learning process was entirely self-directed. I relied on documentation, online courses, experimentation, and hands-on projects. I built systems, broke them, debugged them, and rebuilt them again until I understood not only how they worked, but why they worked. This iterative process taught me discipline, patience, and problem-solving under uncertainty.

At the same time, I was balancing academic responsibilities and preparing for graduate studies abroad. The process was not easy. There were moments of doubt, especially when progress felt slow or unclear. However, I made a conscious decision to continue building rather than waiting for ideal conditions. This decision became a pattern in how I approach challenges.

When I was admitted into my Master’s program in Software Engineering at GVSU, new

challenges emerged. I had to make important academic decisions, including choosing between thesis and project pathways, understanding course requirements, and securing a faculty advisor. At the same time, I was applying for graduate assistantships and trying to align my academic journey with my long-term career goals in DevOps and cloud engineering.

During this period, I actively reached out to professors for research opportunities and academic guidance. While responses were not always immediate or guaranteed, I continued the process without hesitation. I refined my technical profile, strengthened my skills, and consistently searched for opportunities within the university system, including research and graduate assistant positions.

What made this experience truly reflect an “ERLY mindset” was not the outcome, but the persistence behind it. I learned that progress is not always linear, and opportunities do not always appear at the right time. Sometimes, they are created through consistent effort, even in uncertainty.

Eventually, I gained clearer direction regarding my academic path, including understanding the Master’s Project option (CIS 693) as a structured alternative aligned with my one-year academic plan. This clarity did not come instantly; it came through continuous communication, exploration, and adaptation.

Beyond academics, this mindset has deeply influenced how I approach technology itself. In cloud computing and DevOps, systems are inherently complex and unpredictable. Deployments fail, pipelines break, and infrastructure behaves in unexpected ways. Instead of being discouraged by these challenges, I learned to treat them as part of the learning process. Each failure became an opportunity to improve system design, automation, and resilience.

Today, “betting on myself” is not a single decision I made in the past, but a continuous mindset that guides my actions. It means trusting my ability to learn new technologies, adapt to unfamiliar environments, and persist even when results are not immediate. It means taking responsibility for my growth rather than waiting for external validation.

Receiving the ERLY Scholarship would not only provide financial support but also reinforce this journey of self-investment. It would allow me to focus more deeply on my studies, hands-on projects, and professional development in cloud computing and DevOps automation without additional financial pressure.

My long-term goal is to become a cloud and DevOps engineer specializing in scalable infrastructure, automation, and distributed systems. I aim to contribute to building reliable and efficient systems that support modern digital services at scale.

Ultimately, my journey reflects a simple belief: meaningful progress comes from the courage to bet on yourself before certainty exists. Every step I have taken so far has been guided by that principle, and it continues to define the direction of my future.